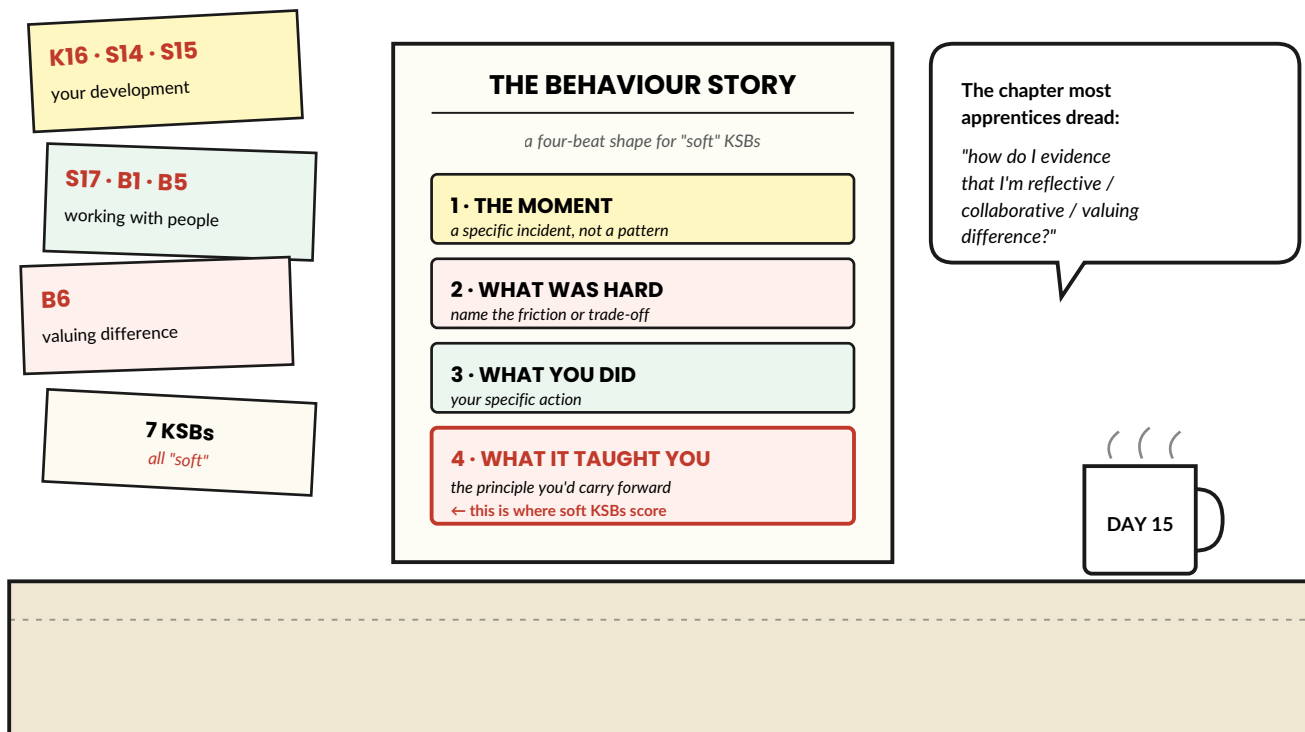


15

fourth content area • the soft ksbs

Approach to Work, STARR-ed

K16 • S14 • S15 • S17 • B1 • B5 • B6 — the "people" KSBs

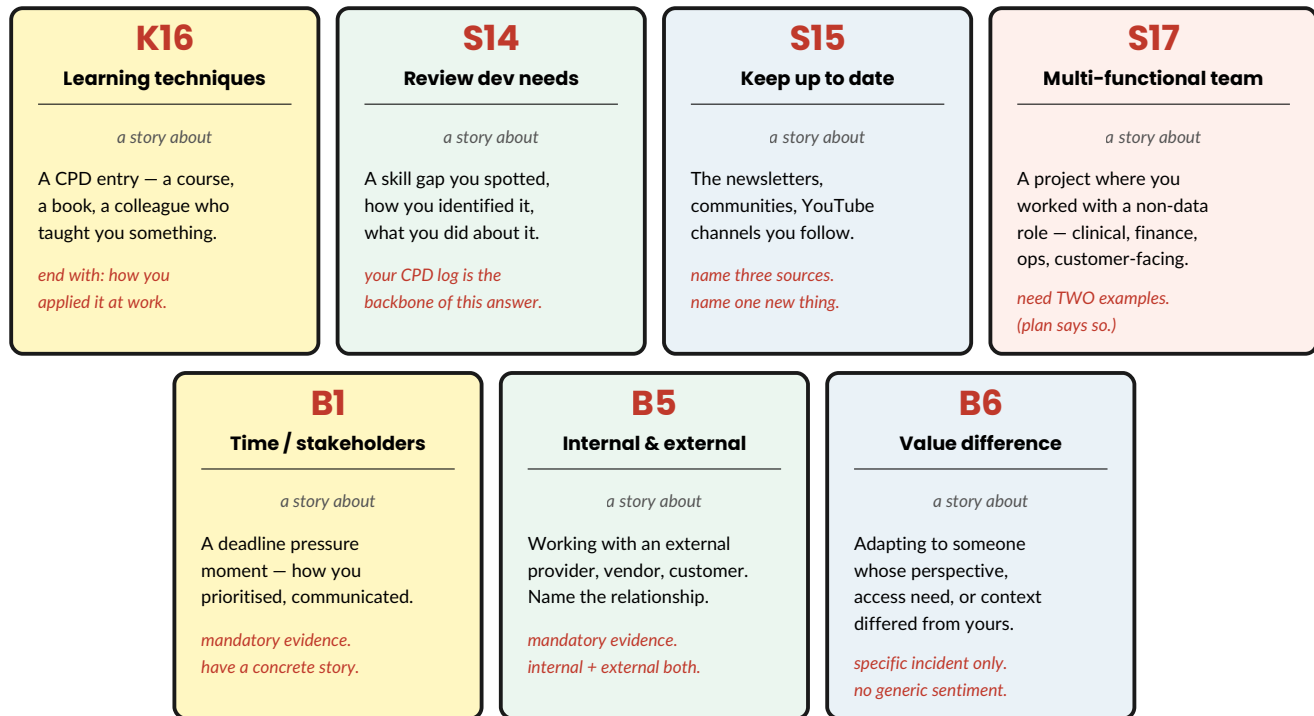


Seven soft KSBs. The chapter most apprentices dread because the answers feel intangible. Today's named device, **The Behaviour Story**, gives you a four-beat shape that turns "I worked well with people" into specific, defensible, scoreable evidence.

What sits inside Approach to Work

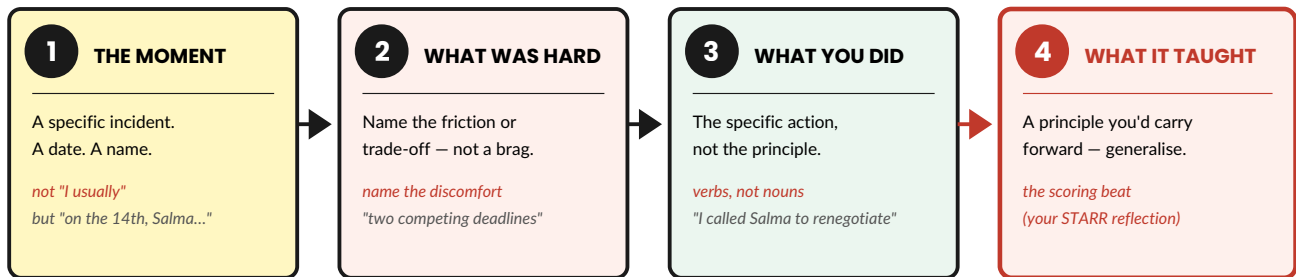
Each KSB needs one specific workplace story. Below: what the story should be about, and the trap to avoid for each.

THE SEVEN SOFT KSBS · AND THE STORY THAT EVIDENCES EACH



The Behaviour Story

The trap for soft KSBs is being general. *"I'm collaborative."* Doesn't score. The Behaviour Story is a four-beat shape that forces specifics: a moment, a friction, an action, a learning. It sits inside the Action+Reflection layers of STARR.



SHOW THIS OFF

The two killers of a soft-KSB answer: **generic** and **self-congratulatory**. The Behaviour Story fixes both. Specific incident + named friction + named action + generalised principle. Try saying *"What I'd carry forward from that..."* — it's the cleanest entry to beat 4.

Two worked Behaviour Stories

One soft KSB, one specific incident, one Behaviour Story. Below: B1 (time management) and B6 (valuing difference) each as a four-beat answer.

Example 1 — B1 (manage own time and stakeholders)

- 1 • Moment.** *"In October, finance wanted the quarterly reconciliation by the 15th and clinical wanted the PTL refresh by the 12th — same week, same dataset, conflicting deadlines."*
- 2 • What was hard.** *"Both were time-critical for different reasons; the PTL drove patient bookings, the reconciliation drove invoice payments. Neither stakeholder knew about the other ask."*
- 3 • What I did.** *"I went to both leads on the Monday with the conflict named explicitly. We agreed the PTL would land on the 12th (clinical priority) and the reconciliation on the 16th (one day later, with finance's sign-off)."*
- 4 • What it taught me.** *"Naming a conflict early is cheaper than negotiating around it later. I now front-load the deadline conversation on any project where two stakeholders share a dataset."*

Example 2 — B6 (value difference)

- 1 • Moment.** *"In June, a colleague who relies on a screen reader asked me to share dashboards differently — my colour-coding was invisible to them."*
- 2 • What was hard.** *"I'd built the dashboard for visual scanning — conditional formatting in red/amber/green. The accessibility re-work meant rethinking the layout from scratch."*
- 3 • What I did.** *"I added a textual flag column ('OK / Warning / Action') alongside the colour code, and changed the colour palette to one that works for colour-blind users too."*
- 4 • What it taught me.** *"Accessibility isn't an extra layer — it's a quality standard. Every dashboard I've built since starts with the text-first version, colour added second."*

Where soft-KSB answers fail

1. The general statement

"I work well in teams." Doesn't score. Replace with: a specific date, a specific colleague, a specific task. The Behaviour Story's beat 1 fixes this.

2. The self-praise

"I'm proactive and a strong communicator." Doesn't score — sounds like a CV. Replace with: a moment where being proactive was hard, what you did, what it taught you.

3. The skipped reflection

You tell the story, name the action, and stop. Beat 4 (what it taught you) doesn't happen. The KSB descriptors specifically ask for reflective thinking — without it, the answer reads as just narrative.



RED FLAG · THE FAKE STORY

Don't invent incidents. If a KSB doesn't have a real workplace example, find an adjacent one — a college project, a previous job, a volunteer role. "I haven't had that exact situation at work, but..." beats a manufactured incident every time. Assessors smell rehearsed-but-not-lived stories.

4. The one anecdote stretched too far

One story can cover 2-3 KSBs, but not all 7. If you find yourself returning to the same project answer for K16, S14, S17, B1, B5 and B6, the assessor will notice. Aim for 3-4 distinct Behaviour Stories.

5. The "soft skill" framing

Don't call them "soft skills" in the discussion. The KSB descriptors use them as *professional behaviours*. Use that vocabulary: "my approach to managing stakeholder expectations" rather than "my soft skills around stakeholders".



SHARPEN YOUR PENCIL 40 minutes — one Behaviour Story per KSB

For each of the seven soft KSBs, name ONE specific incident. A few words is enough — the full story comes when you say it out loud.

KSB	What the KSB asks for	The moment / incident (a few words)
K16	learning techniques	
S14	review own dev needs	
S15	keep up to date	
S17	multi-functional team (NEED TWO)	
	...and a second example	
B1	time / stakeholders	
B5	internal + external customers	
B6	value difference	

For each filled row: can you say beats 2 (what was hard), 3 (what you did), and 4 (what it taught you) out loud? If not, the row's not ready — revisit before Day 16.

Halfway House

Five quick questions.

1. The Behaviour Story has four beats: moment, what was hard, what I did, what it taught me.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

2. "I'm proactive and collaborative" is a strong opening for a soft-KSB answer.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

3. S17 (multi-functional team) needs at least two examples.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

4. One strong workplace story can cover all 7 soft KSBs.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

5. If I can't recall a real workplace example for a KSB, I should invent something plausible.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

Answers

1. **True.** The four-beat shape that fits inside STARR Action + Reflection.
2. **False.** Generic claim, no evidence. Replace with a specific incident.
3. **True.** The plan explicitly says S17 requires two scenario-based examples.
4. **False.** Aim for 3-4 distinct stories – one stretched too far reads thin.
5. **False.** Use an adjacent example (college, previous job, volunteer). Invented incidents fail authenticity tests.

There are no *Dumb* Questions

Q: *I find soft KSBs the hardest to talk about. Is that normal?*

A: Very. Most data techs got into the role because they like the technical work; talking about feelings, teamwork, learning style feels alien. The Behaviour Story is the structural fix — you don't have to be "good at" reflection if you have a four-beat template you can fill in.

Q: *I don't have a formal CPD log. How do I answer S14?*

A: An informal one counts. A list of courses, blog posts you read, YouTube channels, conversations with seniors that taught you something. Pull it together as a one-page list before the discussion — the assessor wants to see *some* record, not necessarily a corporate template.

Q: *For B5 (internal + external customers) — what counts as "external"?*

A: Anyone outside your immediate team. A different department in the same organisation usually counts as "internal customer" rather than external; external is partners, vendors, contractors, members of the public. If your work is entirely internal, name a partner / vendor interaction even if it's small (a software vendor support ticket, a data provider query).

Q: *My B6 example feels small — just one accessibility change. Is that enough?*

A: Yes. B6 is about valuing difference and being sensitive to needs — not about leading a diversity initiative. A specific accessibility change, a language adjustment for a non-native English speaker, a meeting format change for a colleague who works part-time — all valid.

Q: *The assessor asked something I've never had to do. How do I answer?*

A: Two options. **One:** describe how you'd approach it if it came up — named principles count even without a real story. **Two:** if relevant, bring up an adjacent experience — *"I haven't had to handle a difficult external customer in this role, but earlier in my career I..."*. Honesty plus reasoning beats a manufactured anecdote.

Say it for real

Q1 — Tell me about a time you had to manage competing deadlines or stakeholder demands.

The shape: Behaviour Story. Beat 1 names a date and the two stakeholders. Beat 4 generalises into a principle you'd carry forward.

Q2 — Describe a piece of professional development you've undertaken and how it changed your work.

The shape: Behaviour Story for K16/S14. Name the development (course/book/colleague), name the moment you applied it. The beat 4 is the bridge: *"what that taught me about how I learn was..."*

Q3 — Tell me about working with someone whose perspective or working style differed from yours.

The shape: Behaviour Story for B6/S17. Specific person (anonymised if needed), specific adjustment you made, specific principle you carry forward. Don't try to sound like a diversity training; sound like someone who noticed and adapted.

SHOW THIS OFF

Open soft-KSB answers with a date and a name. *"In October, working with Salma in the booking team..."* instantly signals specificity. Vague openers (*"I generally find..."*) cost marks; specific openers earn them.

Bullet Points — the chapter in 30 seconds

- Seven soft KSBs. K16, S14, S15, S17, B1, B5, B6. None is Distinction-graded.
- The Behaviour Story. Four beats: Moment • What was hard • What I did • What it taught me.
- S17 needs two examples. The plan explicitly requires it.
- B1 and B5 are mandatory-evidence. Have concrete examples ready — with names and dates.
- Don't generalise; don't self-praise; don't invent. Specific, honest, reflective.
- Aim for 3-4 distinct Behaviour Stories across the seven KSBs — one stretched too far reads thin.
- Open with a date and a name. That alone earns marks.

TEST DRIVE

Tick each only when it's true:

- ☐ You can name a specific workplace incident for each of the seven soft KSBs.
- ☐ For S17, you have two distinct examples.
- ☐ You can recite the four beats of the Behaviour Story from memory.
- ☐ You've practised at least one full Behaviour Story out loud.
- ☐ You can finish the sentence "*What I'd carry forward from that...*" for each story.

COMING UP — DAY 16

The Distinction Lift. Tomorrow we go back over all four content areas with one focus: turning Pass-level STARRs into Distinction-level ones. Named device: **The Why Layer**. Side-by-side Pass vs Distinction answers from every content area. This is the chapter that closes the gap most learners arrive with: hitting Pass everywhere, but the answers falling short of Distinction depth on D1, D2, D3.

that's Day 15 done — the four content areas, rehearsed.